the side. We finished the match without losing a wicket in our second innings, handing the Australians a ten-wicket defeat.

A crushing loss in the first tour game was the worst possible start for the world's best team and was more than we could have hoped for. We now needed to carry the momentum forward into the first Test match in Chennai. Of course, I was well aware that the Australians had not played all their cards against Mumbai. Even when we were attacking Shane Warne, not once did he bowl from round the wicket into the rough outside leg stump. I was certain he would do so at the first available opportunity in Chennai, and I even said as much in the post-match press conference in Mumbai. The series was nicely set up.

First Test, Chennai, 6–10 March 1998

Having played a lot of cricket in Chennai, I knew that the physical preparation in the lead-up to a Chennai Test has to be different from normal. You have to prepare your body for the heat and humidity well in advance and I always did so at least thirty-six hours before the match by drinking a lot more water than normal. The extra water intake was particularly important, because you lose so much fluid during matches at the Chidambaram Stadium.

Nowadays, unlike in the late 1980s and 1990s, when there wasn't much research about players' diets and training schedules, cricket is much more sophisticated about such matters. There are specialized dieticians who draw up charts of what players can or can't eat. After long and arduous batting stints, players take ice baths and drink specially prepared shakes to rehydrate the body and replace lost energy. For example, I remember Paddy Upton, our high-performance trainer, asking me to drink two glasses of a shake made of crushed dry fruits after a particularly draining innings at Gwalior in 2010.

At Chennai, we won the toss and opted to bat first. It was an important toss to win, as the ball was expected to turn in the fourth innings and we were playing three spinners in Anil Kumble, Rajesh Chauhan and Venkatapathy Raju. Despite a good start, with the top three of Mongia, Sidhu and Dravid all scoring fifties, we lost our way in the middle of the first innings and failed to push home the advantage, getting bowled out for a modest 257. Batting at number four, I managed just four runs and fell to Warne. I hit him for a boundary and then tried to repeat the shot,